

Right in Denial



APPOINTED: Avionics expert **Dr K. Radhakrishnan** as the chief of Indian Space Research Organisation. He was the director of Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre and succeeds Dr G. Madhavan Nair.

Whatever happened to the Alternative? The counterpoint to the left-of-the-centre argument that had swayed India since Independence? Oh yes, we thought it was the beginning of the end of Congressism as the official theology of power. We thought Indian democracy was stepping into the age of bipolarity. For the shift was historic, and many certainties of the Nehruvian project in secularism were shattered. For once, the Right was not a blasphemy—or a repudiation of the India of the founding fathers. The BJP in power was the legitimisation of an argument that challenged the cosy assumptions of left-liberal India. And in retrospect, those who won the mandate of an impatient India were not worthy of the romance. The BJP is losing India; it is fast vanishing from the national mindspace. It's more than a story of rejection. (The party still rules some of the big states of India.) It's a story of betrayal—and of fossilisation. The betrayal began with the party's initiation into power. It was a hallucinatory experience for many of its veterans, especially for the one who travelled the most as the warrior-charioteer of the Right, when the party began its life in power. The BJP closed its mind the moment it became the ruling party, and it had nothing to offer except the reassuring graciousness of one man, the only human face in a house of holograms. Now that Vajpayee is an overwhelming absence, the BJP is a party whose worst enemies are those who claim to be its liberators—all discredited losers.

They have abandoned an idea whose time has not passed in an India that is still home to almost every variation of social-justice politics. Still trapped in the wreckage of two general election defeats, they seem to have no idea about the aspirations and attitudes of 21st century India. They have lost the culture war as well as the economic war—the two wars the Right has been fighting in most democracies. It invariably loses the culture war and wins the economy. The BJP still lives in a distant yesterday which is part mythol-

ogy, part history, part nostalgia and part

fantasy. It doesn't have the audacity to be truly "right" in the marketplace. And it doesn't have the imagination to be creative in the social arena either. (Want to be inspired? Look at David Cameron, most likely the next British prime minister by June 2010. If it was economy for Lady Thatcher, it's society—the Broken Britain—for the young Conservative leader. He is winning the economic argument too.) Still, India has not become the Congress country. The space is

there but the party is invisible. To

regain the mind of India, the BJP has to start the struggle all over again—and rediscover the uses of argument against transgressions of power. Isn't it the right moment to get an idea of India as well, particularly so when the winners are in the danger of falling into the illusion of immortality? The BJP has to discard a lot first.

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DIED: Malayalam actor **Adoor Bhavani** who featured in over 500 films and plays. Her last film was *Oru CBI Diary Kurippu*.

INAUGURATED: By Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, the **Anantnag-Qazigund Rail Link** at Anantnag in J&K. This is India's highest broad-gauge railway station at an altitude of 1,722 m.

DIED: Archbishop **Daniel Acharuparambil**, 70, head of the Latin Catholic Church in Kerala. He was president of the Kerala Catholic Bishops Council, the Kerala Region Latin Catholic Bishops Council and the Kerala Regional Latin Catholic Council.

